

Glyptemys insculpta

Wood turtle



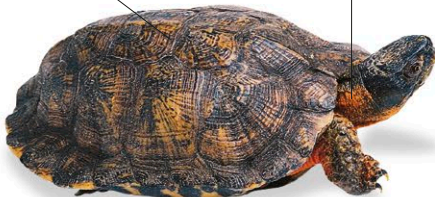
Length 5½–7½ in (14–19 cm), max 9 in (23 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Endangered

Location S.E. Canada, N.E. USA



Besides being an unusually good climber, the wood turtle is a natural wanderer, and is often found crossing fields or roads, particularly after rain. The scutes on its carapace have concentric ridges, and their somber colors provide it with effective camouflage. Wood turtles are omnivores, eating worms, slugs, insects, and tadpoles, as well as leaves, berries, and other plant food. They mate in water, and the females lay 7–8 eggs a year in flask-shaped nests. At one time, the adult turtles were caught in large numbers for food.

pyramid-shaped scutes
reddish skin on neck and legs



Terrapene carolina

Carolina box turtle



Length 4–8½ in (10–21 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiterrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location E. USA

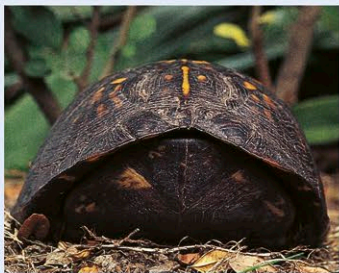


Known to have lived for as long as 100 years in captivity, in the wild the Carolina box turtle prefers damp habitats, such as meadows, floodplains, or moist, forested areas. Very active in the mornings, particularly after rain, this omnivore forages for slugs, worms, mushrooms, or berries. To escape the heat, it retreats into cover or mud at midday and in midsummer, and survives the cold winter months by hibernating. Females can lay fertile eggs for several years following a single mating. The adults have few natural predators, but the young turtles fall prey to mammals such as raccoons, and birds of prey.



domed shell

BOXED IN



The front section of the Carolina box turtle's plastron is hinged, so that when the turtle withdraws its head into the shell, the front of the plastron can be raised, effectively shutting the animal into a protective "box."

TAN TURTLE

This individual has a tan shell, but some Carolina box turtles are mainly orange or yellow, and others may be quite dark, with radiating yellow lines.

Trachemys scripta elegans

Red-eared slider



Length 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Near threatened

Location S. Central USA



yellow-marked green shell
red stripe behind eyes



Identified by a prominent red stripe behind its eyes, this freshwater turtle is just one subspecies of the many species that live in lakes, rivers, and creeks in North America. Like many of its close relatives, it is fond of basking in sunshine, sometimes forming stacks where basking sites are in short supply, but it is quick to dive into the water if disturbed. As an adult, it lives almost entirely on plant food, but its young eat tadpoles and aquatic invertebrates.

Dermochelys coriacea

Leatherback turtle



Length 4¼–6 ft (1.3–1.8 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Vulnerable

Location Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide



Weighing up to 1,770 lb (800 kg), the leatherback is by far the largest of the marine turtles, and one of the animal world's greatest oceanic travelers. Tagged individuals have been known to cross the Atlantic. Leatherbacks also range into cold waters at high latitudes, thanks to a limited ability to generate body heat. Physically, they differ from other marine turtles not only in size, but also in having a narrow, leathery shell, and flippers without claws. Leatherbacks feed primarily on jellyfish, and their throats have backward-pointing

spines to prevent their slippery prey escaping. They usually feed near the surface, but they can dive down to 1,300 ft (400 m)—perhaps as much as 3,300 ft (1,000 m)—holding their breath for up to half an hour. Although normally found in the open ocean, leatherbacks gather inshore during the breeding season, when males scramble for females arriving to lay their eggs. As with other marine turtles, the females have a strong homing instinct that guides them to a particular stretch of beach, and they lay eggs on dark, moonless nights to avoid being seen. The hatchlings' shells are covered with small, pearly scales, which soon disappear.

CONSERVATION

Leatherbacks nest on sandy tropical beaches, providing an opportunity to gauge the total population at sea. The results are alarming: in the past 2 decades, leatherback numbers have slumped, with far fewer coming ashore to lay. Measures to protect leatherbacks include a complete ban on their capture; in addition, their eggs are collected and incubated in safe conditions, so that their young can be released into the sea.



EXCURSION ASHORE

Emerging from the sea to lay eggs, a female leatherback laboriously hauls herself up a beach. On average, she may spend less than 2 hours a year on land.

5 ridges along leathery carapace

large head on short, thick neck

